

Hurley, Patrick J. and Joseph DeMarco. *Learning Fallacies and Arguments: A Multimedia Tutorial for Critical Thinking*. Belmont, CA: Wadsworth, 2001. \$19.95. CD-ROM. ISBN 0-534-52013-8.

Learning Fallacies and Arguments, an interactive CD-ROM authored by Patrick J. Hurley and designed by Joseph P. DeMarco, is a good use of modern technology with a solid backdrop of modern pedagogy.

With minimal system requirements (100 mhz CPU, 32 megabytes of RAM, 4x CD-ROM drive), this Windows and McIntosh compatible product allows nearly every college student or campus lab access to its wisdom. With a browser driven interface running on either Netscape Navigator or Internet Explorer, the use of Shockwave technology seamlessly guides the user from page to page. Download icons are present for both Shockwave and Netscape when the computer's CD-ROM drive is opened. Clicking on those icons will take a computer connected to the internet directly to Shockwave and Netscape websites, in which free versions of needed software can be downloaded. In the version of the product reviewed, it appeared as if the initial use of the CD-ROM might present some obstacles to the barely computer literate since no auto-start menu pops up once the CD-ROM is inserted, at least with Windows ME platform machine used for this review. This reviewer needed to open the CD-ROM drive and then click on one of the available icons to start the program. Even with this minor annoyance, this CD-ROM coupled with a modest classroom explanation and demonstration should easily fit into the curriculum choices of any college argumentation teacher.

On the positive side, once inside the familiar browser environment, the interface is extremely user-friendly. The HTML design by Kara Kindstrom coupled with the Shockwave treatment and overall design by DeMarco make for a seamless work of art that college students, especially those already familiar with "surfing the net," will find easy to navigate. The introduction to the program includes a voice-over by Hurley and a demonstration that includes the purpose and location of the program's key features and navigation landmarks, such as the repeat and content buttons.

Learning Fallacies and Arguments effectively addresses the diverse learning styles of college argumentation students. Within each topic area, the user is asked to make choices, such as selecting which sentence or main clause is the claim of an argument. Immediately, the user is notified as to whether the choice is correct, and, if incorrect, is given an

explanation of the mistake or a hint about the correct answer. This interactivity is an effective learning tool for the kinesthetic-tactile learner who needs immediate feedback from choices made in each topic area.

For auditory and visual-verbal learners, the CD-ROM exceeds expectations. The oral explanations and clear text involve both the auditory and visual-verbal learner at a high level of engagement. However, the introduction, Venn diagrams, and cartoon art vignettes minimally engage the visual-nonverbal learner. To be fair, most CD-ROM products currently on the market purposefully make little effort to involve visual non-verbal learners, who need a wider array of video, photos, demonstrations, and nonverbal visual displays. The 91.9 megabytes of this CD-ROM do not allow much room for space intensive pedagogical choices. Software developers in today's academic market currently must choose between respecting the minimal system configurations of many users (as well as keeping production costs low) and developing a video intensive product for the nonverbal learner. It is a true dilemma that the developers of *Learning Fallacies and Arguments* chose to resolve by keeping their technological demands modest. Within this self-imposed constraint, they did a good job of producing a well-rounded instructional aid.

While overall the attempt to adapt to diverse learning styles is adequate, the effort to address other aspects of diversity is hit-and-miss. On the positive side, there is a good gender balance – a woman's voice-over instructs students on the argumentation half of the CD-ROM, and a man's voice-over instructs students on the fallacy-identification half as well as the introductory components. During the fallacy-identification cartoon vignettes, the two apparently white college students, Tracy (woman) and Mike (man), are guilty of an equal number of fallacies, keeping the outcome as nonsexist as possible. However, there are only two people of color in the segments in which drawings or photos of people are featured, and they are two students merely sitting in a college classroom. None of the major players are people of color. The hit-and-miss nature of the diversity treatment detracts from a product intended for consumption in an academic market. Playing devil's advocate, however, the developers may not have wanted to portray students of color committing logical fallacies. Aside from a photo of Hurley, whose ethnicity cannot absolutely be determined (although he appears not to be a person of color), the only other persons to play major roles in the CD-ROM are the two cartoon characters in the fallacy vignettes. In all, the diversity component could have been given greater attention by the developers, but there

is not enough evidence to indict this product given how little we know about the circumstances.

While the design and ideological components are, with minor objections, above average, the organization and content features are superior. The CD-ROM is thoughtfully conceived, involving a well-ordered sequence of steps to help students understand arguments and fallacies. There are two components to the CD-ROM: one that helps students understand the nature of deductive and inductive argument, and a second that helps students identify and avoid fallacies. The argument half of the product is quite involved, with numerous exercises designed to help students truly understand the author's concept of argument. Although married to a formal approach to logic, the explanations nevertheless avoid the pedantic language and symbols of the "if P, then Q" approach to teaching logic. Instead, an extremely readable and digestible set of steps leads students to a fundamental understanding of the basics of argumentation and logic. The first few parts of the argumentation segment take students through the nature of argument, including an extremely efficacious treatment of argument versus assertion, conclusion versus premise, and inductive versus deductive reasoning. When handling the often cumbersome issue of assessing the validity of syllogisms, the reader is taken through some very difficult concepts with relative ease.

In the fallacy segment, each of the concepts is laid out in a comic-strip format, with well-drawn cartoon characters. Each fallacy is depicted with its own vignette, cleverly and clearly elucidating the fallacious reasoning of the characters. Following each vignette is an explanation by Hurley. College students should have little difficulty following the in-depth explanations that specify the sentence from the comic strip during which a fallacy is committed and the reason for the fallacy. Each segment of the comic strip appears in full screen format, and the audio dialogue is accompanied by full text subtitles. While there is no full-action video, the cartoon segments are well conceived, and allow the user to click the mouse button to advance the vignette to the next frame in the strip when he or she is ready to do so.

Overall, this CD-ROM by Patrick Hurley and Joseph DeMarco is an effective teaching tool that involves a readable and digestible content. The design elements are simple and effective, but without the full use of technology that would make this product a world-class academic endeavor. Keeping in mind the high cost of high-end technology and the low-end system configurations of many users, this product is competitive in a market characterized by low technology ancillaries and classroom aids. Additionally, diversity elements may

have had to play a back seat to technological and content-related concerns. However, *Learning Fallacies and Arguments* is a welcome addition to a sparse field of technological aids for logic and argumentation, where publishers are not inclined to spend their money, instead reserving sparse resources for the public-speaking arena, where a larger academic market resides.

Joe Corcoran
Santa Rosa Junior College

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